

Web Cams

With the Internet getting faster and cheaper, Web cams will provide better voice and video capture facility and therefore talking to your relatives and friends is bound to get even more realistic. The same camera will work automatically—no human assistance will be required.

Facts

Web cams need good Internet speeds to work well. You will need anything between 10 to 15 Kbps, while the average Internet speeds, especially using dial-up, available to the home users are far below this, so the webcam will deliver choppy video i.e. the frame rate will be very poor.

Compare the features of the webcams before buying, take into the consideration purpose of your use resource that are available to you and then make the decision.

Like speed and image quality, a webcam is only good if you can use the image you collect. If you use the Web cam for long hours, or outside in a dim light, you must select a camera that is capable of operating in such demand-

ing situations. Generally speaking if you are in a dimly lit area you will require a camera capable of operating around 1 lux.

Lens: Lens is heart of the Web cam. Lens acts as an eye that focuses on the scene. The area coverage and focus distance depends on the lens implementation. Most entry level webcams are fixed focus.

CMOS: CMOS is the sensor that turns the light information in to the digital signal. It then forward it to the PC where it is represented as an image.

Manual Focus: Some Web cams allows for manually focus on the subject within the allowed perimeter. For the rest you will have to do the moving part

Motion Capture: This is the feature of the software. With this feature enabled Web cam will take a snapshot if any thing moves in the frame.

Do Remember

❑ As far as possible try to avoid the cheap Taiwanese and Chinese brands as they can hardly match the quality provided by branded Web cams.

Buying Tips

- ✓ Get a Web cam that captures video with at least 30 FPS if you are getting frames below this then your video could be too slow jerky or choppy
- ✓ Try a Web cam that can adjust with light condition; good brands to look at are Creative Labs, Logitech, IBM. To ensure the video is not too dark or washed out.
- ✓ Consider the various standards H.320, H.263 and H.261 standards for superb

connectivity if you are going to use it for video conferencing. A Web cam with a lower resolution works on less bandwidth and is a better option to use it when chatting with your friends and relatives.

- ✓ The software which comes with the Web cam is also important as it can provide you with better tweaking features and capture pictures for you. Also look for video conferencing over LAN and WAN support.

Ready Reckoner



You Need

VGA web cam for internet chatting and recording small clips occasionally.

Look for

Entry-level USB web cams



You Need

Web cam that supports over 800x600 resolutions with microphone built in to it. It should also be able to click images.

Look for

Web cam with hardware support of 800x600 pixels with some level of zoom control



❑ Good Web cams are less susceptible to light variation and hence produce better quality video in all lighting conditions.

❑ Before you buy a Web cam check the true resolution it offers and not the interpolated that is often mentioned in bold letters. Higher the native resolution better the quality of the video.

❑ Some new generation Web cams allow tilt, pan and zooming features; they come handy if you plan to use it as a surveillance device.

❑ When buying Web cams for you laptops pay careful attention to the clamping mechanism. Some Web cams have flimsy clamps that break easily.

❑ Some manufacturers have launched Web cams in credit card format, these cameras can double as digital cameras reproducing low quality photographs—just good enough for sending over mail.

❑ Before you plan to use a Web cam for video-chatting ensure that you have enough bandwidth.

❑ If possible checkout the software provided with the web-camera, they make all the difference when it comes to hogging system resources.